Kashmir and Punjab. The strategic importance of friendly relations with Afghanistan and their impact on Pakistan was not overlooked, but India's final policy approach had at least two angles to it. The existence of the partisans and the conciliators vis-à-vis the Taliban proves this point. Both the coalitions saw the center of gravity for most Afghan and Indian security problems in Pakistan. As scholar Chris Ogden argues, 'Pakistan's support of various insurgencies and terrorism against India has ... entrenched the contemporary Pakistan-terrorism nexus within India's (foreign and domestic) security perspectives'.[187] However, different coalitions advocated different approaches to the problem. The conciliators advocated engagement with the Taliban and all those warring factions deemed unfriendly to India and close to Pakistan. The partisans advocated selective engagement with only those factions that had a positive predilection towards India (or a negative predilection towards Pakistan).

The late-1990s phase of partisan domination in Indian foreign policy experience paved way for the narrative that the Afghanistan conflict was a byproduct of the India-Pakistan rivalry. Though partially true, this argument conflates political interpretation and beliefs with policy outputs. It misses the rise of the conciliators in the late 1980s and early 1990s, and is based on a stringent assumption that India-Pakistan rivalry is cast in stone. Even if it is true that most Indian officials view Afghanistan through a security-dominated Pakistani lens, and most Pakistani officials view it through a security-dominated Indian lens, the policy outputs over time indicate nuance and political sophistication. Based on this credible but partial understanding of the policy narratives that influence India's approach towards Afghanistan, most contemporary studies foresee an imminent proxy war between India and Pakistan in Afghanistan. India, as this chapter shows, did indeed engage with and accommodate pro-Pakistan factions after the Soviet withdrawal in 1989 until 1996. The Taliban's rise to power in Kabul in September 1996 challenged India's conciliatory approach. Nonetheless, the decision to sever ties with the Taliban and to bolster anti-Taliban factions was highly debated in New Delhi. Many in India saw the Taliban as a militant Islamist force sponsored by Pakistan. For others, however, it was an ethno-nationalist movement representing Pashtun interests, and not necessarily under Islamabad's control.